

A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- A new independent report, "The Cost of Waiting," sets out the safeguarding and welfare risks of prolonged SEND provision delays, drawing on FOI responses from 16 local authorities.
→ **For your school:** *A useful citable source when escalating a case where interim provision has stalled or a specialist placement is delayed.*
- The statutory suspension and exclusion guidance that came into force 26 July is now the framework schools are actually operating under as term gets underway, with new duties on off-site direction extended to academies and PRUs.
→ **For your school:** *Check your managed-move and off-site-direction paperwork reflects the new requirements, not last year's version.*
- Ofsted's September 2026 update to inspection handbooks is now live, covering early years, schools, independent schools, FE & skills and ITE providers.
→ **For your school:** *Skim the schools-specific changes before your next inspection window, however distant it feels.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

- 18 Sep 2026** — DfE EOTAS (education otherwise than at school) consultation closes.
- 18 Sep 2026** — Rotherham Schools Forum meets — agenda includes the exclusion & suspensions annual report and an EHCP update.
- Ongoing, Sep 2026** — FSM eligibility rechecks: transitional protections from the Universal Credit expansion are unwinding this term.

■ INCLUSION & SEND

- **"The Cost of Waiting" — new report on SEND delays.** The report examines what happens when children with SEND can't access suitable education for prolonged periods. It argues schools and local authorities should weigh the wider educational, emotional and safeguarding implications of reduced timetables or waits for specialist placement, and calls for more consistent recognition of urgency, better data collection, and expedited holistic reviews where a child's vulnerability is increasing. ([Nasen](#))
→ **For your school:** *Worth having to hand for any EHCP-delay conversation with your local authority this term.*

■ BEHAVIOUR, EXCLUSIONS & ATTENDANCE

- **Exclusion guidance now the live framework for the new term.** The updated statutory guidance on suspension and permanent exclusion — in force since 26 July — is the one schools are actually working to as pupils return. It reinforces that permanent exclusion should be a last resort, introduces a distinct 'safeguarding separation' category separate from disciplinary exclusion, and extends off-site-direction duties to academies and PRUs, alongside strengthened expectations for pupil voice in managed moves. ([GOV.UK](#))

→ **For your school:** Confirm your behaviour policy and managed-move paperwork already reflect the safeguarding-separation distinction.

■ OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

- **September 2026 inspection-handbook updates published.** Ofsted's annual round of updates to inspection materials under the renewed framework is now live, spanning early years, state-funded schools, non-association independent schools, FE & skills, and initial teacher education. ([Ofsted](#))

■ FUNDING

- **FSM expansion transitional protections start unwinding.** Free school meal eligibility extended to all Universal Credit households from September; schools should expect eligibility-recheck activity through this term as transitional protections from the previous system phase out. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ NATIONAL POLICY

- **DfE Update, 9 September 2026.** The department's regular fortnightly bulletin to schools and trusts was published this week; these updates typically carry grant deadlines, data-collection windows and operational guidance rather than headline policy, so worth a scan for anything time-limited. ([GOV.UK](#))

■ SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **Rotherham Schools Forum meets 18 September.** The agenda includes the exclusion & suspensions annual report, an EHCP update, and early 2027/28 budget planning — a useful read-across given Sheffield's own high-needs budget pressures. ([Rotherham MBC](#))

JARGON-BUSTER · SAFEGUARDING SEPARATION

New terminology in this term's exclusion guidance:

Safeguarding separation — a temporary removal of a pupil from school premises for safeguarding reasons, which the DfE has now made explicit is NOT a disciplinary exclusion and must be managed through separate procedures, not the exclusions process.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. ([Explore School+](#))

■ SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions

Source	Type	What we track
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; "Who's Losing Learning?"
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.